

“We are neither **warmongers** nor
appeasers ... We are Americans.”

JOHN F. KENNEDY, SPEECH AT THE UNIVERSITY OF WASHINGTON, NOVEMBER 16, 1961

Project Beef Up

Although Kennedy balked at sending US ground forces into action—a course urged by the Joint Chiefs of Staff—he authorized the implementation of Project Beef Up, which more than doubled American military assistance and economic support to the South Vietnamese. The dispatch of US helicopters and Special Forces contingents to support the training of the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) turned the tide for a while, at least according to the reports reaching Washington.

Hopes dashed

Believing that the US was well on its way to achieving stability in South Vietnam, in the fall of 1962 Kennedy instructed McNamara to prepare to wind down the number of US military advisers there to 1,500 by the end of 1965. The plan was never implemented. With the resurgence of the Viet Cong in 1963 and the growth of popular protest against President Ngo Dinh Diem, Kennedy's response was to increase US military assistance. By the end of 1963, there were 16,000 US personnel in Vietnam.